

For the Sin We Committed by Confession of the Mouth

Or: Why the Printed Confession Should Be Omitted

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One of the foundations of repentance, in a person's thinking, is the recognition of man's responsibility for his deeds, which comes from the belief in man's free choice. This is also the content of the confession bound up with the commandment of repentance, in which a person admits that there is no other party to be blamed for the sin and its consequences, but himself alone. And in this he clarifies for himself the freedom of his will and the full power he holds over the course of his life and his deeds, and through this he clears before himself the way to return to God, to renew his life along a good course.

Orot Ha-Teshuvah 16:1

In this passage the Rav explains the special halakhic emphasis placed on confession (viduy). Why is confession considered, in the Rambam's view, the primary implementation of the commandment of repentance? Because repentance begins from the place where a person understands that he is the responsible one, that he alone is at fault. When a person understands that his condition and his deeds depend solely on himself and on his free will, he becomes capable of opening a process of behavioral transformation, of deep change in character and of walking in new and good paths. Only when we step, for a moment, out of the flow of life and examine the great power of human freedom do we suddenly find ourselves asking what I truly want to do with my powers, with my life, with my deeds — where am I going, who do I want to be.

This is not merely about taking on guilt; the taking-on of guilt is an emotional process that occurs after I recognize, in general, that there is sin — that is, that I am unhappy with my present state, with my bad deeds and my flawed character. It seems to me that the foundation of the recognition of human responsibility precedes, both chronologically and logically, the place of guilt. The recognition of free choice, this revelation that, as it were, removes a veil covering our eyes from seeing that we are truly the ones choosing at every moment, even when we do not give our full heart to the deeds that come out under our hands — this recognition precedes and gives rise to the most basic reflection of repentance, to the kernel from which all the feelings of repentance sprout. This awakening, to wake up and discover that we hold the wheel in our own hands, is what brings us to feel who we want to be, and how far we are from that, how much we acted without knowing, out of "a spirit of folly," out of a lack of self-attention, out of our own externality.

Confession is an expression of that very awakening, and it is therefore the first stage of repentance.

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Nowadays we say a printed confession. We are instructed to say — "we have been guilty, we have betrayed, we have stolen," and so on. This is part of the prayer ritual, it is written in the prayer book, and we obey, and our lips mouth this text along with the thousands of words we are required to raise up before God as an offering during the long High Holy Day prayers. Why is the confession printed in the prayer book? Why is there even a "formula" for confession at all, when confession is, at its core, a personal stance and a particular engagement with a specific sin or sins? One can propose two layers. The first reason for this is simple, and it is the halakhic wish to bring everyone into the framework, so that everyone has some reasonable minimum of connection, of standing before God. On a deeper level, halakhic practice seeks to create a field of opportunity, of opening possibilities; it chooses a certain sum of words, with the motivation being that the individual not remain on this level, but succeed — out of the technical act, out of the pre-formulated words, out of the ritual — in "connecting," in sliding into the depth of the matter, in entering his inner world, in opening himself to the meanings of things.

But today I think that the printed confession is one of the greatest tragedies of the High Holy Days. Indeed, words have a wondrous power to penetrate and influence from the outside inward. Even words said, at first, out of a certain self-compulsion, out of an incomplete heart, out of a lack of sincerity in some sense, often succeed, in the very act of being said, in flooding us with sincere feelings, in raising true thoughts, in arousing deep desires and yielding authentic experiences. Therefore, I do not at all oppose the saying of an "initiated" confession, one that does not burst forth from a person's natural, flowing emotional conduct. The fact that halakha and custom "obligate" the saying of confession as part of the formal religious demands of the month of Elul, of the High Holy Days and of Yom Kippur, seems to me reasonable and even positive. Except that we must pay attention to whether, in the way this is customarily done today — formulated down to the last detail, and leaving no empty space for creative and independent formulation — we are not achieving precisely the opposite of what is sought.

Confession, as noted above, expresses the shaking-off of the unconscious flow of life, and the awakening to a sense of responsibility, freedom and choice. The speech of confession is meant to be an awakening speech; it is meant to open me to the most foundational question — "where am I in all this?" A person who says confession is a person who revives within himself the point of his own self, the point of independence — it depends on nothing but me, I am responsible, I brought myself to the place where I am, and I can also change this, I am the one who determines whether to be good or bad, it is all in my hands alone, I can, from this moment on, be who I truly want to be. Reading a confession out of a printed prayer book expresses the exact opposite; not only does it fail to wake me, it even signals to me something contrary — everything follows the script, everything, all of it, is part of the film written in advance. I am guilty, but this has already been written for me in the prayer

book — that I will be guilty, and that I regret, and that I have sinned (and that I will sin?) in this and in that. This is part of the unchanging facts, part of the reality of the world, it is not really, really me. It is natural, it is inevitable, and it also repeats itself, again and again, like the cycle of the year — every Yom Kippur I say the same confessions, I pour out the same words about the same sins (whether mine, or the community's, or someone's in general), I call out cries of breaking and desolation, weakness of hands and nothingness, I say that we should remember that we are dust, I ask forgiveness before the Searcher of hearts and minds — and all this as part of the annual ritual of atonement.

Confession, the foundation of repentance, is the opposite movement — there were no scripts, there were no reasons, there are no excuses — this is all me and only me, I who am unique, I who am unlike anyone else, I and my own choice, I and my own guilt. And not only this, but that this is truly free; I am truly capable of being somewhere else from this moment on, of getting up tomorrow morning differently, in a new place, in a better place, and I am truly capable of arriving, next year, at Yom Kippur, and being happy with myself, being full of myself. And if this does not happen — it is only because of me, only because I did not try hard enough.

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So What in Practice?

Before saying — if one says at all[1] — the printed confession, stop. Dwell for a moment in personal thought, thought formulated before myself in my own words. Where am I? Am I here? Where am I in life? Am I present in it? Do I choose it? Are my choices good? Are they correct, are they sincere, are these truly my own choices?

Confession is not measured by the quantity of sins we managed to mention, but by the quality and the depth of the standing before my own choice, my own self.

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Notes

1. Whoever is able would do well to omit the printed confession and say only a personal confession (during the silent Amidah). This requires a bit of courage, but it is usually preferable to dragging along dozens more words in which nothing really happens.